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SICILIAN CAMPAIGN

COMMANDER-IN-CHIEF'S DISPATCH

AFH - 1943

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Commander-in-Chief's Dispatch

SICILIAN CAMPAIGN

1943

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THE DECISION

The decision to undertake the conquest of SICILY was made at the Conference held at ANFA Camp on the outskirts of CASABLANCA in January 1943, by the Combined Chiefs of Staff in session with President Roosevelt and Prime Minister Churchill. I was present only one day, January 15th, to report on the progress of the TUNISIAN campaign, but I was kept informed of decisions in so far as they related to this Theater, and at the conclusion of the deliberations I was sent a complete set of official minutes. I was thus advised, not only of the decision to conquer SICILY, but of the over-all strategic considerations which produced the decision, and these were quite as important for me to know as a guide to detailed planning.

The Conference met to determine the basic strategy for the year 1943, and although American and British Joint Staffs were agreed that priority must be given the effort to destroy the European members of the Axis before an all-out effort could be made to conquer JAPAN, it was by no means clear in January what particular major operation would serve the purpose best. Rommel was on the run from EGYPT and TRIPOLITANIA, but victory in TUNISIA had yet to be achieved, and the probable junction between Rommel and von Arnim for defense of the Axis' TUNISIAN bridgehead did not make the prospects of rapid victory any brighter. I had already abandoned all hope of being able to mount a major offensive with General Anderson's First Army in Northern TUNISIA before the middle of March, and although I had decided to concentrate a mobile flank guard in the TEBESSA region, in order to hold on to vital airfields, and with some hope of putting on a limited offensive against SFAX to cut Arnim's line of communications with Rommel, I had to abandon the latter portion of this purpose on January 15th when I learned at ANFA that General Alexander could not reach the MARETH Line in time either to support it or to profit from it. Nevertheless, the Conference decided that the crucial stage would be reached in TUNISIA within a few weeks and that it must consider what major operations should be undertaken once the NORTH AFRICAN shore had been finally cleared of Axis forces.

Tentatively my staff had been planning an operation against SARDINIA which could be undertaken 6 weeks to two months sooner than an assault on SICILY, because it was much less heavily defended and required fewer forces to be trained and mounted, but such an operation could hardly weigh very heavily in the scales of Allied effort against the Axis at a time when it was essential to divert as much German strength as possible from the Russian front. Moreover the capture of SARDINIA would have had a profound effect in the MEDITERRANEAN only if coupled with the immediate capture of CORSICA, and with the further object of attacking ITALY from the flank as quickly as possible. With SICILY still in Axis hands, possession of SARDINIA could not improve our shipping situation materially, and about the only positive advantage it, as a separate objective, had to offer was advanced air bases from which we could bomb the industrial areas of Northern ITALY and the Southern coast of FRANCE more effectively.

The real question was whether to undertake any major operation at all in the MEDITERRANEAN after the conclusion of the TUNISIAN campaign. There was very general agreement that something must be done as soon as possible to relieve the strain on RUSSIA, and it was clear to everyone that an operation against SICILY could be mounted much sooner than any effective invasion of the European Continent via Northern FRANCE, because of the greater present availability of both shipping and manpower in the NORTH AFRICAN Theater.

I understand that the SARDINIA versus SICILY case was argued ex-

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haustively at the Conference. My own view was that if the firm intention was to assault ITALY as quickly as possible, then the SARDINIA - CORSICA operation was correct, not only because time would be saved, but because our new position would threaten ITALY throughout its flank. On the other hand, I felt that if the purpose was primarily to clear the MEDITERRANEAN for our use (a primary mission of my original directive) and to draw German forces southward, then SICILY was indicated as our proper objective. This operation had the further advantage of some flexibility in later broad decisions - after we had it we could decide whether or not to go into ITALY. On the other hand, if we took SARDINIA and CORSICA we had nothing except a base for future operations, and the SICILY - PANTELLERIA barrier still stood between us and our use of the MEDITERRANEAN.

On January 19th, the Combined Chiefs agreed that offensive action would be undertaken in the MEDITERRANEAN in 1943 for the conquest of SICILY with the object of (a) making our line of communications in the MEDITERRANEAN more secure, (b) diverting as much German strength from the RUSSIAN front as possible, and (c) intensifying the pressure on ITALY, - hoping that such results might create a situation in which TURKEY could be enlisted as an active ally. The following day, the Combined Chiefs of Staff directed the planners of both countries to examine all possible expedients which could advance the date of the operation and to report the earliest feasible target date.

It is a remarkable fact, given the uncertainty of the general military situation and the tremendous complexity of planning a major amphibious operation, that the Conference, six months in advance, should have decided, even tentatively, on the exact period when the attack was to take place. On January 22nd, the Combined Chiefs resolved that the target date should provisionally be set for the favorable period of the July moon, which, as later interpreted in the light of the decision to drop airborne units during the night prior to assault by ground forces over the beaches, meant the period July 10th-14th. The decision was necessarily tentative, because of the variety and complexity of the factors to be considered, none of which lent themselves readily to scientific measurement, and all of which were so interdependent as to make separate estimates impossible. There were the questions of landing craft, both for training and mounting; of the ports to be used for mounting; and relevant to both questions was the further question of the approximate date when it would be reasonable to suppose the NORTH AFRICAN shores and ports would be finally cleared of the Axis.

The decision was based on the hypothesis that NORTH AFRICA would be cleared by April 30th, and General Sir Alan Brooke, who mentioned that date specifically, likewise made another well-educated guess when he estimated the duration of the SICILIAN campaign at six weeks. Brooke explained the later target date calculated by the British Planners as based on their preference that the British share of the expedition be mounted from NORTH AFRICA in order to save escort vessels, and to avoid the enormous risks of sending a convoy from the UNITED KINGDOM through the SICILIAN NARROWS on D-Day. The British assumed that none of the TUNISIAN ports would be available to them either for training or mounting, both because there could be no certainty of their being cleared of the Axis in time for adequate training, and because United States forces might require the TUNISIAN ports as well as all the ALGERIAN ports. Under these circumstances the British would be confined to the MIDDLE EAST ports - HAIFA, ALEXANDRIA, PORT SAID, TRIPOLI and MALTA. The MIDDLE EAST mounting would actually mean a saving of 65 assault vessels of the total 190 required if the expedition were mounted in the UNITED KINGDOM, but the training bottleneck in the MIDDLE EAST ports would delay the target date nearly a month beyond that required for an expedition mounted from the UNITED

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KINGDOM. In the latter case the British Planners thought an early August date possible, although reluctant to assume the additional costs in terms of escort vessels and of increased risk. The MIDDLE EAST mounting which they preferred would defer the date to the end of August.

Brooke himself thought the British Planners were too pessimistic, and he told the Combined Chiefs that in his own view the date could be advanced to July, even on the same set of assumptions which guided the British Planners. Although his own planners would not follow him, they did agree that the date might be advanced in the event that TUNISIA had been cleared of Axis forces before April 30th, and in case ports both in TUNISIA and further West could be made available to them. The United States Chiefs were willing to guarantee that the British might use some of the TUNISIAN ports when they were cleared, and with this much leeway, the Combined Chiefs decided tentatively on the favorable period of the July moon as the target date for the SICILIAN operations.

I had, meantime, been preoccupied with the TUNISIAN campaign, but, on January 23rd I was notified by the Combined Chiefs that detailed planning for operations against SARDINIA was to stop and that a directive for a SICILIAN campaign would be issued shortly. The directive issued by them vested in me the supreme command of the operation, with General Alexander as Deputy Commander-in-Chief, in direct command of ground forces, and with Admiral Cunningham and Air Chief Marshal Tedder as naval and air commanders respectively. I was to be charged with the over-all responsibility of the detailed planning, of the necessary preparations, and of the execution of the actual operation. I was likewise given limited discretion with regard to the target date for the campaign. The Combined Chiefs, themselves, decided to explore the possibilities of an even earlier date - that of the favorable period of the June moon - but they notified me that in my study of the detailed planning I was to report any difficulties of either resources or training which might defer the July date. By March 1st I was to report any such difficulty and I was directed by that date to confirm that postponement would not defer D-Day beyond the favorable period of the August moon at the latest.

The question of exact date was not finally settled until April 13th. Before our planning got well under way, the Combined Chiefs of Staff directed me to work for a target date within the favorable period of the June moon on the assumption that the TUNISIAN campaign could be terminated by the 30th of April. We made the most detailed examination possible and I concluded that preparations for such an early date were impossible without cutting into the essential training period to a dangerous extent. In a communication to the Combined Chiefs of Staff on February 11th I pointed out the difficulties in detail. Whereas several of the divisions could be trained and mounted in time from MIDDLE EAST ports, from the UNITED KINGDOM and the UNITED STATES, one of the divisions we proposed to use - the U.S. 3rd - would probably be employed in the TUNISIAN campaign and we could not be sure of its readiness for a new campaign in June, even if TUNISIA were clear by April 30th. Mounting in the TUNISIAN ports after their conquest was certain to be a very complicated affair, and the preparation of airfields in TUNISIA with the build-up of the necessary 50% bomber and 100% fighter reserves would require four weeks. Taking all these factors together with the lack of sufficient landing craft for the timely training of armored units, I stated that in our view a June assault was unlikely to succeed.

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On the 19th of February the Combined Chiefs of Staff replied that the favorable period of the June moon must remain the target date and that all preparations must be pushed with the utmost vigor to achieve it; they directed me to report on April 10th how far advanced our preparations were by that date; but I was left free to tell them at that time if I still

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judged the June date to be impracticable, and in that event to report the earliest possible date that could be met. On March 20th I reported that it was the unanimous opinion of all my commanders that June 10th was an impossible date to meet and that no date before July 10th would be possible, unless there were to be an unexpected and almost immediate collapse of the Axis in TUNISIA. On April 10th I reported definitely that it was impossible to achieve the June date, but that barring unforeseen circumstances, the state of our preparations should make the July date possible. The Combined Chiefs replied on April 13th, approving my decision for the July D-Day.

In the early stages of detailed planning I had not merely to watch TUNISIA, but to keep my eye on SPANISH MOROCCO as well. After the initial landings in NORTH AFRICA, I had maintained substantial forces in ALGERIA and in FRENCH MOROCCO to guard against any Axis attempt to operate through SPAIN against our line of communications. I had moreover to plan for operations not only against SPANISH MOROCCO, but against the IBERIAN Peninsula as well, in order to be able to counter at once any German attempt to threaten us through SPAIN. Such plans tied up forces needed for the operation against SICILY, and I had no choice but to reduce our insurance against enemy action from SPAIN, at least during the period when the TUNISIAN campaign absorbed so much of my available resources. Consequently General Clark was notified on January 21st that shipping and landing craft allocated to IBERIAN operations would not be available for that purpose after March 1st and that by that date I would need staff personnel from the Northern Task Force - also designed for the IBERIAN operation - for a special staff to do the detailed planning for the SICILIAN operation. Northern Task Force was therefore to be released entirely from its commitment to the SPANISH venture from March 1st. On February 6th the Combined Chiefs advised me that forces held in the UNITED KINGDOM for the SPANISH operation were to be released to us at once.

THE PLANNING STAFF

The Combined Chiefs had decided that the meticulous task of preparing the detailed plans should be undertaken by a special operational and administrative staff, - with its own chief of staff - which would be free of the responsibilities of the TUNISIAN campaign. It was understood that, in view of my wider responsibilities as Commander-in-Chief of the entire Allied Force, General Alexander, as my deputy, would assume immediate command of the SICILIAN operation, but since both he and I, as well as my own group of planners at A.F.H.Q. were almost entirely preoccupied by the direction of the NORTH AFRICAN campaign, I established a special planning staff under Major-General C. H. Gairdner, to represent General Alexander; he was succeeded by Major General A. A. Richardson during the early part of May. Since the operation was ultimately to come under the direction of a British general, the combined staff was organized according to the British system, just as for the NORTH AFRICAN operation the American Commander's staff had been set up on American lines.

A nucleus staff was got together on February 10th, and because of the crowded conditions at the St. George Hotel, was established in the Ecole Normale at BOUZAREA, a suburb of ALGIERS. It carried with it, however, some of the flavor of the St. George, because it received official designation as "H.Q. FORCE 141", derived from the number of the hotel room in which members of A.F.H.Q. had first met to discuss the possibilities of a SICILIAN campaign. It was the embryo from which 15th Army Group Headquarters grew, but for the time being it remained a sub-section of G-3 at A.F.H.Q., which maintained firm control. In the absence of a special G-2 Section at BOUZAREA, the staff was especially dependent on A.F.H.Q. G-2 for intelligence which had to be obtained by a special liaison section, an arrangement which resulted in a not altogether satisfactory production of intelligence in the earlier period.

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Admiral Cunningham set up a special planning section of his staff at the Ecole Normale at the same time, and this staff worked in close cooperation with FORCE 141 throughout the planning stage. But I was not able to solve satisfactorily one of the major problems of organized planning, namely the physical difficulty of bringing together in one place all the personnel concerned with the various aspects of a complicated major operation involving land, sea and air elements. Army and other subordinate headquarters dependent on H.Q. FORCE 141 were widely scattered, some of them being as much as 1000 miles from each other, with resultant misunderstanding and loss of time in reaching decisions.

The U.S. members of the staff were drawn from Fifth Army Headquarters, I Armored Corps, and Atlantic Base Section, with a few from A.F.H.Q. and from the UNITED STATES. The British members came from the UNITED KINGDOM, MIDEAST, and A.F.H.Q. The staff grew steadily as planning became more and more detailed and by May 1st had almost attained the size of an operational staff. On May 15th, "H.Q. FORCE 141" officially became an operational staff, independent of, but subordinate to A.F.H.Q. Throughout, A.F.H.Q. attended to the details of implementing 141 FORCE plans by coordinating the enormous effort of mounting troops in widely scattered areas - the UNITED STATES, the UNITED KINGDOM, MIDEAST, and NORTH AFRICA itself.

STRATEGIC CONSIDERATIONS

The Island of SICILY forms a natural bridge between the tip of TUNISIA and the ITALIAN mainland. Shaped like a jagged arrowhead with broken point toward the West, it is 140 miles long and 110 miles wide across the barbs at the Eastern end. The Western point, CAPO BOEO, or LILIBEO, is only 90 miles Northeast of CAP BON in TUNISIA; the South-eastern barb, CAPO PASSERO points directly South to MALTA only 55 miles away; the Northeastern barb, CAPO PELORA is separated from the CALABRIAN Peninsula at the toe of ITALY only by the STRAITS of MESSINA, which narrow to a width of barely two miles. So far all the traffic had been one-way, and it was my task to reverse it. I had not merely to destroy the enemy in TUNISIA, but to seize his bridge, in order to secure a firm base from which to launch further offensive action.

Obviously, it was much easier for the Axis to get men into SICILY than it was for us. According to the Tactical Appreciation, there were six train ferries operating daily across the STRAITS of MESSINA, with four termini in MESSINA itself, and three on the ITALIAN side - two at SAN GIOVANNI and one at REGGIO, and the 24-hour capacity of this service was estimated at 40,000 men, or 7,500 men and 750 vehicles. Actually these were highly theoretical figures, because never more than two of the ferries operated at this time, but there was also a steamer service whose capacity we estimated at 12,000 men every 24 hours, and a shuttle air transport service with an estimated capacity of 1,000 tons daily. We knew positively of at least 19 airfields which the Axis possessed in SICILY, divided into three groups - East, Southeast, and West - of which the Eastern and Southeastern groups were mutually supporting, and all of them at least 15 miles inland from the coast.

MESSINA was the most important objective on the island, but it was out of the question to launch a direct assault on the STRAITS of MESSINA, or at any point between MESSINA and PALERMO to the West or between MESSINA and CATANIA to the South. The STRAITS were completely closed to Allied shipping and beyond the range of Fighter cover, and the same was true of the areas immediately West and South of MESSINA. Possible areas of debarkation were limited to the beaches where direct fighter cover could be provided, between AVOLA and GELA in the Southeast and between SCIACCA and MARINELLA in the West, and in these areas there were no major ports to provide unloading facilities.

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Under these circumstances the advantages of terrain were chiefly with the defenders. The beaches on which my forces had to land were of gentle gradient and soft sand, peculiarly difficult for initial landings, and above all for the landing of motor transport. They were, moreover, relatively narrow, and, apart from the wide coastal plain at CATANIA in the East Central section of SICILY, they led quickly into country which was always hilly and frequently mountainous, particularly in the center of the island and in the Northeast, with MOUNT ETNA to provide a magnificent bastion in the final defense line protecting the vital MESSINA area. Tanks and motor transport would be needed in the initial assault in order to cope with enemy armor, but tanks could not be used freely except in the coastal areas of CATANIA, the Southeast, and the West, and once our forces penetrated into the mountainous areas, motor transport would be confined to the comparatively few roads. It was anticipated that for the transport of heavy mortars and other equipment we might eventually have to rely on pack animals some of which could probably be obtained in SICILY. The bareness of the central uplands provided very little cover for the attacking forces and, in order to break through finally into the MESSINA area, our troops would have to traverse a country admirably suited to the enemy's genius for mining and demolition.

The first task, therefore, was to get maximum forces and supplies ashore as quickly as possible at the points where air cover could be provided, but I had to make additional provision for the build-up of these forces by the acquisition of port facilities. The principal ports in the island are MESSINA, PALERMO, CATANIA, and SYRACUSE, and because MESSINA was out of the question, my plans had to provide at least for the capture of SYRACUSE and CATANIA in the East and of PALERMO in the West. In fact my administrative staff concluded at this time that unless we gained control of both CATANIA and PALERMO we could not maintain a sufficient number of divisions in SICILY to conquer the island, whereas in our possession these ports would maintain the equivalent of 10 1/2 divisions together with air forces. There was the further consideration that capture of PALERMO, in addition to the other ports, would confine the enemy entirely to his MESSINA line of communications and that simultaneous assaults in the East and West would immobilise his reserves. All these ports were beyond the range of fighter cover, and therefore the immediate objective of the assault forces must be the airfields both in the Southeast and in the West to provide the extension of air cover essential for the capture of the ports.

It was agreed that two separate task forces would probably be required for the purpose, and from the beginning we were faced with the greater difficulties in the West. We could cover the actual landings with air protection better in the West than in the Southeast, because of the greater capacity of the TUNISIAN fields as compared with MALTA, but the sea approach to the Southeast was not exceptionally open to enemy air attack, whereas the Western approach was exposed throughout to flank attack by Axis planes based on SARDINIA. Moreover, an Eastern Task Force had a much better chance of achieving surprise, because its approach could approximate more closely a normal convey move. Finally, the preliminary Tactical Appreciation disclosed that the Western landings were essentially more difficult than these in the Southeast.

Although it might appear desirable to make the two attacks as nearly simultaneous as possible, in order to achieve maximum dispersion of the enemy's air effort and of his ground forces, there was one compelling consideration for staggering them by launching the Southeastern assault first, and there were also subsidiary reasons for following that course. The greater possibility of surprise in the Southeast was important, and it was reinforced by the consideration that initial operations in that direction might draw off enemy reserves from the West and thereby render

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less difficult the Western assault. The determining consideration, however, was the decision to employ airborne troops in advance of the first landings, in order to soften the defenses. It was considered essential that all possible transport aircraft be made available to lift the maximum number of parachute troops for the purpose, and that the total lift be applied to each airborne assault in turn. It was desirable that the Western assault take place as soon as possible after the Eastern, but investigation indicated that the earliest possible date was D plus 2. Since the airborne attacks would be designed to precede the seaborne assaults by only a few hours at most, we faced a highly complicated and even dangerous time schedule for staggering two separate assaults, each composed of land, sea, and air elements.

The employment of airborne troops was considered necessary to soften beach defenses, because of the different commitments of the other services. The duties of the naval forces were primarily convoy and it was thought unwise to rely too much on naval gunfire to neutralize shore defenses, both because of the limited number of ships available, and because naval gunnery alone was not thought to be completely effective for the purpose. Nor could we count on airpower for the job, because its primary role was to be the destruction of the enemy airpower. So much importance was attached to the role of airborne troops to accomplish the task, that the Tactical Appreciation rated it even higher on the priority list than the early capture of the airfields.

The use of airborne troops, however, complicated even further the already highly complex problems of timing. Moonlight offered the best conditions for night landing by parachutists, but naval forces required darkness for the approach to hostile shores and it was also essential that the beach assaults take place in darkness about two hours before dawn, in order to establish adequate anti-aircraft defenses ashore before daylight. We could not afford to drop parachutists too long before the landings for fear of giving the alarm too soon, but to drop them in the dark, or even at dusk, was to risk needlessly heavy losses in aircraft and personnel.

The only reasonable compromise we could find was to schedule the attack for the period of the second quarter of the moon, when there should be sufficient light during the early period of the night to minimize dispersion and losses of airborne forces, but complete darkness after midnight when the moon set. Such was the meaning of the "favorable period" of the moon, and once July had been set as the month for the SICILIAN operation, it automatically determined the target date as July 10th.

CHANGE OF PLAN

FORCE 141 - later 15th Army Group - was to be composed of two separate Task Forces, which on landing were to constitute the U. S. Seventh and the British Eighth Armies, but during the planning period they were known respectively as FORCE 343 - the Western Task Force - and FORCE 545 - the Eastern Task Force. On March 18th there was preliminary discussion of plans at Headquarters FORCE 141, with representatives of FORCE 343 and FORCE 545 attending, and a week later the outline plan itself was issued. The essence of the plan was a series of staggered assaults, beginning with the landing of the British troops of the Eastern Task Force on D-Day on beaches extending from South of SYRACUSE in the East to GELA toward the West, followed by the landing of one division of the American Western Task Force on the beaches between SCIACCA and MAZZARA in the extreme Southwest on D plus 2, and the landing of the remainder on D plus 5 in Northwestern SICILY in the area CASTELLAMARE - CAPACI - TRAPPETO, immediately West of PALERMO itself. Five British divisions were to serve as the main body of the Eastern

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Task Force and four American divisions were to constitute the main body of the Western Task Force.

The plan involved a considerable dispersion of our forces which was contrary to my own original suggestions that all available force be concentrated to achieve rapid victory in the Southeast as the best insurance for the conquest of SICILY. I had abandoned this proposal in the face of the maintenance risks that must be assumed unless we provided for the early capture of PALERMO, but even before our outline plan was issued, General Alexander and General Montgomery convinced me that our forces were spread too thin, and that the British FORCE 545 would not be strong enough for the task of capturing rapidly its immediate objectives - the airfields of the Southeast in the CATANIA - GELA sector - unless it were reinforced by an additional division. For the next six weeks I struggled with the dilemma of choosing between two risks - that of being too weak for our immediate objectives in the Southeast, because of the insurance taken for the early capture of PALERMO - and the maintenance risk that must be assumed if we were to sacrifice PALERMO for the sake of decisive strength in the Southeast.

There was no question but that something had to be done to strengthen the assault in the Southeast. Reconnaissance had shown that the airfield near GELA was one of the most highly developed, and Air Chief Marshal Tedder was particularly insistent that the airfield at PACHINO in the extreme Southeast also be captured at once. Failure in the Southeast would probably deprive the Western assault of all hope of even limited success, and even complete initial success in the West could not retrieve a disaster in the Southeast. The salient fact which emerged from our discussions was that without early possession of the CATANIA - GELA fields our entire plan would be abortive, and in the light of this fact the idea of taking the greatest possible insurance for the rapid capture of these fields became our guiding principle.

Our first efforts at solution were in the nature of compromise. The great problem was to find an additional division for the reinforcement of FORCE 545 without seriously weakening the dispositions of FORCE 343 for the assaults in the West. There were sufficient divisions available, but the limiting factor, as always, was the shortage of shipping. All the shipping and landing craft which we expected to be available had already been assigned, and for the moment, the only solution to our problem seemed to be the complete transfer of one of the American divisions - with all its shipping - from the Western to the Eastern Task Force. Since we could not spare any of the forces assigned to the Northwestern landings on D plus 5, for the capture of PALERMO itself, the only alternative left us was to cancel entirely the Southwestern assault scheduled for D plus 2 and to transfer the U.S. 3rd Division to take over the GELA landings from the British.

It was not a satisfactory compromise, because the price for our insurance in the Southeast was high and it was at the expense of the PALERMO objective. The mission of the Southwestern force was the seizure of the airfields in the SCIACCA - MAZZARA area in order to provide close fighter support for the landings in the PALERMO region on D plus 5. Without that support we would have to rely on the longer range fighter support based on the CATANIA - GELA fields of the Southeast - about twice as far away - which had the double disadvantage of leaving the Southwestern fields temporarily to the enemy and of disrupting the schedule for the attack on PALERMO. That attack could not be attempted until we had secured the fields in the Southeast, and since there was no way of calculating just how soon that could be accomplished, we had to eliminate the D plus 5 target date for the PALERMO assault, leaving the date to be determined by the progress of FORCE 545. Our revision of plan thus not only weakened FORCE 343, but condemned its personnel to confinement in idleness aboard its ships for an indeterminate period after embarkation in NORTH AFRICAN ports,

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because the expedition would have to be ready to sail by D plus 3.

These modifications of the original plan did not by any means become fixed. They represented the effort of all concerned to keep constantly abreast of all the various aspects of a complicated problem, and to re-examine all assumptions in the light of new factors as they presented themselves. I continued to re-examine our shipping estimates, with a view to mounting an additional British division within the existing limits, and during the next month or so I was in constant communication with Washington, checking our own estimates with those of the Combined Chiefs of Staff.

The British Joint Chiefs were particularly reluctant to see the Southwestern assault abandoned because of its importance in providing close support for the capture of PALERMO, fearing that in the event of delay the enemy might continue to use it as a port of entry, and that his air forces in Western SICILY might be free to operate against the Eastern Task Force. They communicated their views to the Combined Chiefs of Staff in Washington on March 25th, with the suggestion that an additional division must be provided by hook or by crook without interfering with the dispositions of the original plan to ensure the capture of PALERMO, and their message reached me the next day.

There was some discrepancy between the shipping estimates of the Combined Chiefs and those of my own planners, and the attempt to reconcile them was never wholly successful. For example, on the basis of actual experiment we estimated that 20% of the shore-to-shore landing craft used for training would not be operational on D-Day, whereas Washington held that 10% was an adequate estimate. I also stressed the fact that we must allow for 30% losses in the first assault and for the reduction to that extent of the shipping available for the follow-up on D plus 3. We could not afford too large a vehicle deficit in the follow-up without seriously affecting the mobility of our forces ashore. We could not see our way clear to mounting an additional assault division. We did, however, after carefully considering the views of the British Joint Chiefs, tentatively restore the main outline of our original plan, which included the assault by a U.S. division in the Southwest on D plus 2, and we strengthened the immediate reserve at MALTA from a Brigade Group to a full Infantry Division - neither assault trained nor assault loaded.

My commanders and I were agreed from the beginning that if substantial German ground forces were to be placed in the threatened areas prior to the assault, our operation offered scant promise of success. We assumed that our 9 divisions must encounter a total of some 8 enemy divisions (apart from many static battalions) of which two we expected to be German. The original planning paper prepared by the British Joint Planners for the CASABLANCA Conference had maintained that against well armed and fully organized German forces numbering more than two divisions the landings would be extremely hazardous. We saw no reason to question that judgment, because the assault we contemplated was a frontal one in which we could count on neither strategical nor tactical surprise. Although naturally we rated the combat efficiency of the Italian formations much lower than that of the German, we nevertheless had to assume that the presence of substantial German forces would stiffen Italian resistance correspondingly. We expected that the German formations would be retained as a mobile reserve for counter attack when it was determined where our landings were to take place.

The Tactical Appreciation indicated the probable scale of German troops in SICILY at about two divisions, of which at least one was certain to be fully equipped. Because of the terrain in SICILY, my planners did not anticipate any significant reinforcement of these forces even

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after D-Day, but additional German divisions were available in Southern ITALY and they could easily be ferried across the STRAITS of MESSINA, and there was the further possibility of a voluntary withdrawal of forces from TUNIS-IA. I had to take account of the possibility of German reinforcements reaching the island before our attack, and I felt it my duty to warn the Combined Chiefs of Staff that in that event our venture would become risky indeed. In two separate communications, on March 20th and again on April 7th, I pointed out this danger, but I added that this statement of opinion, in which both my commanders and I concurred, had not in the least affected the intensity of our planning and preparation which were proceeding with the utmost vigor. Although I received something of a rebuke from the Combined Chiefs for my warning as implying a lack of confidence in Allied arms, I reiterated that there was no thought at Allied Force Headquarters but to carry out our order to the ultimate limit of our ability.

The sharpness of my dilemma became even more acute in the latter part of April, when both Air and Naval commanders became insistent that our Southeastern assaults must immediately acquire for our use at least the airfields of COMISO, PONTE OLIVO and BISCARI, as a guarantee against prohibitive losses in shipping, which would endanger subsequent operations in the Southeast and possibly prevent our Western assaults entirely. The Eighth Army Commander, on the other hand, was reluctant to divide his forces for the achievement of such scattered objectives, and maintained that, in any case, his ground forces were not strong enough to do more than interdict the use of these airfields to the enemy, without being able to guarantee their use to our own air forces. Both arguments were entirely sound and the apparently irreconcilable conflict between them merely illustrated the fundamental weakness of our entire strategic plan, which in attempting - with limited resources - to achieve too much at the same time in too many places, risked losing all everywhere.

After long conference, all commanders agreed that the airfields of the Southeast must be secured in the first rush, and that all available strength in both task forces should be concentrated to achieve that objective. On May 3rd we stopped tinkering and completely recast our plan on the sound strategic principle of concentration of strength in the crucial area. I abandoned not only the Southwestern assault scheduled for D plus 2, but the assaults West of PALERMO on D plus 5 as well, and diverted the entire Western Task Force to the Southeastern assault. I deliberately assumed the maintenance and supply risk involved in the sacrifice of PALERMO as an immediate objective, because all of us were at last convinced that it was the lesser of two evils. Major-General C.H. Miller, Senior Administrative officer of FORCE 141, pointed out that we were ignoring the experience of the NORTH AFRICAN landings which proved that a force must have a port for its maintenance within 48 hours of landing, but suggested that this lesson might not be applicable to the SICILIAN case, because of; (a) the better weather prospects in mid-summer; (b) the greater certainty of air and sea superiority; (c) the progress in technical equipment, particularly the D.U.K.W., which he strongly urged both Task Forces to study and train with, to ensure that their utmost capabilities should be realized. On May 4th I advised the Combined Chiefs of Staff of the basic change in plan and stated that "the lessons we have learned here as to the difficulty of driving Axis troops from mountainous positions have convinced all commanders that the SICILIAN plan should provide concentrated strength at critical points even at the cost of additional risk in maintenance and supply."

The Combined Chiefs approved the change. During the TRIDENT Conference sessions in WASHINGTON, some of the Joint Planners thought the revised plan might prolong the operation into September, but the Combined Chiefs saw no reason to revise their estimate that the conquest of SICILY, if begun on the target date of July 10th, could be concluded within roughly a month. The British Air Chief, Air Marshal Portal, thought it a weakness

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in our new plan that the port of PALERMO might remain open to Axis reinforcements, but he counted on the enormous Allied air superiority to neutralize the port and actually to seal the island. On May 13th, the very day when Axis resistance finally collapsed in TUNISIA, the Combined Chiefs advised me that they approved the general type of the new plan as I had outlined it to them.

On the same date they accepted my decision not to attempt any hastily improvised scheme to exploit the TUNISIAN victory by advancing the date of the assault on SICILY. On May 11th I had notified them there were no possible expedients or short cuts which would permit even an improvised operation to be mounted before the middle of June, and that I therefore planned a different sort of prelude to the major SICILIAN operation scheduled for July 10th. Since one of our major problems was to provide fighter cover for the SICILIAN attacks, I decided to attempt the capture of PANTELLERIA about June 10th.

The Tactical Appreciation had pointed out the danger to our operations from enemy possession of the island, but concluded that although its possession by us would be a valuable asset, its capture would scarcely be worth the effort, and that all necessary purposes could be achieved by neutralizing it from the air. After conference with Admiral Cunningham and Air Chief Marshal Tedder, however, I decided not only that we must have possession of this advanced base for 100 fighters, but that we must deny to the enemy the use of his R.D.F. stations on the island. On May 13th, the Combined Chiefs cabled that they understood the reasons for the decision and concurred. The operations against PANTELLERIA form the subject of a special report which I have already forwarded to the Combined Chiefs of Staff.

PLANS

Our altered strategic conception involved a fundamental change in the tactical plan, and it upset completely our logistical plan based on the early utilization of PALERMO's port facilities; it did not affect the broad plans for the allocation and disposition of resources to the two task forces. It meant a reallocation of objectives between the Eastern and the Western Task Force, and it extended the original objectives in the Southeastern area Westward from GELA to include the small port of LICATA, but with this exception all the objectives had been studied. Finally, the new plan retained the same general combination of land, sea and air operations.

An amphibious operation of such magnitude required the closest coordination between Army and Navy planners, and although we could not annihilate the physical distances which too frequently separated them, the details of military and naval cooperation were finally worked out with both precision and harmony.

In the nature of the case it was much more difficult to weave the air plan into the same intricate pattern. Unlike the Army and the Navy after the conclusion of the TUNISIAN campaign, Air Force operations against the enemy on a major scale never ceased; the special operation against PANTELLERIA in June engaged a far larger proportion of air strength than of either military or naval resources. Moreover, apart from the fixed targets provided by the enemy's bases and communications, the chief objective is always the enemy's air force, a fleeting and frequently a fugitive target, impossible to pinpoint in advance. Finally, the problem of maintaining constant direction of a complicated campaign of this sort necessitated the highest degree of centralization of air force command, whose chiefs were usually too busy to participate personally in consecutive detailed planning with Army and Navy representatives, and reluctant in view of other commitments, to assign represen-

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tatives authorized to make firm commitments in their name to the other services. Under these circumstances, the air plan was certain to appear imprecise when compared with military and naval plans, and both military and naval commanders were equally certain to receive little advance assurance as to exactly how much air support they could expect.

*New York 4/10/44
TO COMNAV C-4*

It was agreed among the planners of all services that the primary role of our air power in all phases of the attack was to neutralize the enemy air force and to provide maximum security for the shipping and the assault beaches against enemy air attack, and that until that mission had been definitely accomplished, the scale of air effort available for direct support of naval and military operations was certain to be strictly limited. Our air forces enjoyed a wide margin of superiority over the Axis in the ratio roughly of 3700 combat aircraft against 1570 - of which more than 800 were German - counting all those based in SICILY, SARDINIA, ITALY, and Southern FRANCE. Such a margin was certain to be decisive, but was unlikely to assure the required supremacy without a struggle. Accordingly one of Admiral Cunningham's operation orders emphasized that much of the air support provided would be beyond the horizon of the forces benefiting from action against enemy aircraft and against the bases from which they operated; called upon the Navy to recognize that its own requirements represented a considerable drain on the resources of the Air Force; and warned the Navy to be prepared to face a considerable scale of bombing and torpedo attacks from hostile aircraft.

Every element of the Allied Air forces in the MEDITERRANEAN Theater was allotted its special task. During the assembly period of the convoys, MIDDLE EAST command was to provide fighter protection for the convoys from MIDDLE EAST ports, while Coastal Air Force furnished protection for convoys from NORTH AFRICAN ports. During the preliminary phase, Strategic Air Force was charged with a continuing mission against the enemy's air bases and communications, and Tactical Air Force with the close range missions more immediately preparatory for the assault itself. Tactical Bomber Force was to carry out light bomber attacks against selected objectives in the Western Task Force area and medium bomber attacks in the Eastern Task Force area, fighter escort for the bombers being provided in the former case from TUNISIAN bases, in the latter case from MALTA.

During the approach and assault phases XII Air Support Command of Tactical Air Force was charged with direct air support, although with emphasis on the qualification that such support must remain strictly limited until the enemy air forces had been neutralized and maximum security had been provided for shipping and beaches against enemy attack. Until single-engine fighters could be established in SICILY, day and night protection for shipping off the beaches was to be provided from MALTA and PANTELLERIA; to be supplemented if necessary by twin-engine fighters from TUNISIA. It was expected that at the conclusion of the preliminary phase on D-1, the heaviest commitment of the fighters would be the protection of convoys, and on D-Day itself the protection of beaches and shipping. During D-Day fighters were to be so fully committed that support bombing would be possible only in exceptional circumstances.

✓ Channels were provided for the transmission of special requests by the separate Task Forces for additional protective air cover or for direct support during the assault phase, as well as for all other auxiliary air missions - including strategic bombing and night reconnaissance - subsequent to the assault phase. It was also stated that after the movement of air forces to SICILIAN bases the heavy commitment for the protection of the beaches would be reduced and fighter bombers would become available for support bombing - escorted light and medium bomber attacks against selected objectives by day and unescorted missions by night.

As I outlined my immediate plans in a June 7 message to the War Department, I described them as a series of simultaneous seaborne assaults, assisted by airborne landings, to seize the ports of SYRACUSE and LICATA

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and the airfields within striking distance of the Southeastern coastline between these two ports, in order to establish a firm base for operations against the AUGUSTA, CATANIA, and GERBINI airfields. In all, the landings were to cover about 100 miles of coastline, extending from CAP MURRO DI PORCO, just South of SYRACUSE, around the Southeastern tip of SICILY at CAP PASSERO, and Westward to LICATA.

Admiral Hewitt, U.S.N., commanded the Western Naval Task Force which was to land General Patton's U.S. Seventh Army, and Admiral Ramsay, R.N., the Eastern Naval Task Force conveying General Montgomery's British Eighth Army. Eighth Army was assigned the Eastern sector, where the immediate objectives were the port of SYRACUSE and the airfield at PACHINO in the heart of the CAP PASSERO peninsula. XIII Corps was to assault the beaches immediately South of CAP MURRO DI PORCO with 5th Division on a two-brigade front, 50th Division on a one-brigade front, and 3rd Commando; while the beaches on three sides of PASSERO were to be taken by XXX Corps with 231st Brigade, 51st Division on a one-brigade front, Canadian 1st Division on a two-brigade front, and 40th and 41st Royal Marine Commandos. After capture of its immediate objectives XIII Corps was to press Northwards for the capture of the port and airfield at AUGUSTA, and subsequently the airfields in the CATANIA and GERBINI region; while XXX Corps moved Northwest to effect junction with the right flank of U.S. Seventh Army. The latter force was to effect landings at CAP SCALAMBRI, SCOGLITTI, GELA and LICATA. U.S. 1st and 45th Infantry Divisions comprising II Corps were to seize the airfields at COMISO, BISCARI, GELA and PONTE OLIVO just West of the British sector, while a special force composed of the U.S. 3rd Infantry Division and one armored Combat Command from the U.S. 2nd Armored Division captured the port and airfield at LICATA, and the remainder of the 2nd Armored remained as floating reserve.

Two airborne missions were designed to clear the way for the invasion forces, although the original proposal of direct airborne attack on beach defenses was eliminated from the final plan. An hour before midnight preceding the dawn landings, an Airborne Brigade of the British 1st Airborne Division was scheduled to drop by parachute and in gliders in the area immediately South of SYRACUSE to seize a vital bridge and important points commanding the town, while four battalions of the U.S. 82nd Airborne Division executed a parachute drop in the area behind GELA to clear obstacles for the advance on PONTE OLIVO.

The mounting, assembly, and supply of the assault forces was a gigantic undertaking which required the closest coordination between four separate theaters and taxed our shipping supply to the limit. The British 5th and 50th Infantry Divisions and the 231st Infantry Brigade were to be mounted in MIDDLE EAST, the 1st Canadian Division was to be mounted in the UNITED KINGDOM, and the British 51st Division in TUNISIA, partly staging in MALTA. As follow-up the British 78th Division and Canadian Army Tank Brigade were to be mounted in the SOUSSE - SFAX areas of TUNISIA and transported shore to shore with 21 days' maintenance and 10 days' reserve. The 51st Division was to bring with it 21 days' maintenance plus 10 days' reserve, the Canadians from UNITED KINGDOM 24 days' maintenance plus 10 days' reserve, and the forces from MIDDLE EAST 7 days' maintenance. Subsequent maintenance for all British Forces was to be the responsibility of MIDDLE EAST until the D plus 42 convoy. The U.S. 45th Division, mounted in the UNITED STATES, was to bring with it 21 days' maintenance, the U.S. 1st Infantry Division was to bring 7 days' maintenance from its mounting base in NORTH AFRICA, and the U.S. 3rd Infantry Division was to be maintained from its NORTH AFRICA base by landing craft and coaster ferry service. U.S. 9th Division as follow-up was to bring 7 days' maintenance from NORTH AFRICA.

The abandonment of PALERMO's port facilities as an immediate objective of the assault created a serious supply problem for FORCE 343 whose

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new assault area offered not a single port of the importance of PALERMO or CATANIA or SYRACUSE. LICATA which lay within the assault area had an estimated capacity of 600 tons per day as compared with 1000 for SYRACUSE, 1800 for CATANIA, and 2500 for PALERMO. Whereas FORCE 545 could count on the early use of ports to supplement supply over the beaches, FORCE 343 had to recast its plans in order to arrange its entire supply over the beaches until D / 30; the first convoy loaded in the UNITED STATES was due to put into SICILY on D / 14. To meet this difficulty special arrangements were made with FORCE 545 for the partial use of SYRACUSE after D / 14 in case of necessity, and a special American liaison Group of 2,500 service troops was scheduled to arrive in SYRACUSE in D / 10 with two MT Store Ships and two LST's to establish depots near SYRACUSE in order to forward supplies to FORCE 343, even prior to the arrival of the convoy.

The administrative arrangements devised to take care of the complicated questions of maintenance and movement were largely governed by three factors: firstly, the wide distances which separated Headquarters and formations during the planning period and at the time of embarkation; secondly, the participation of two Armies with totally different administrative systems, on which I commented at some length in my dispatch on the "TORCH" operation; and lastly by the combination of the first two factors with the existence in the theatre of two widely separated bases from which these operations must be launched and maintained. This led General Alexander to decide that it was neither necessary nor desirable to establish an Allied Headquarters with executive logistical functions for the coordination of the logistics of the two Armies prior or subsequent to their engagement with the enemy.

Consequently, the Army Group organization, with its limited logistical responsibilities but which had proved a satisfactory solution in the closing stages of the TUNISIAN campaign, was continued for this operation but with one essential variation. Should the course of operations demand the coordination of American and British administrative arrangements after contact with the enemy, as would occur if it became necessary to use a single port for the support of both Armies, H.Q. 15 Army Group decided to appoint an agent for this purpose. The selected agent was H.Q. TRIPOLI Base Area - re-named FORTBASE - which was to be moved to SYRACUSE as soon as practicable after the capture of that port.

In fact, FORTBASE was never called upon to exercise its coordinating function, nor were the special facilities for supplying the U.S. Seventh Army from SYRACUSE ever put to use, because the extraordinary performance of the D.U.K.W.'s in unloading over the beaches provided adequate facilities for Seventh Army until the conquest of PALERMO, earlier than anticipated, afforded an independent harbor base. At PALERMO Headquarters, Seventh Army, and later Island Base Section administered the supply requirements of United States forces, while FORTBASE administered Eighth Army supply from SYRACUSE.

Thus, there were never brought to light the difficulties inherent in the application of an organization specially designed for one purpose, the TUNISIAN campaign, to circumstances which might have been completely different in another, the SICILIAN campaign. Nevertheless, difficulties did arise, in the main in connection with the movement of build-up forces, which would have been more readily overcome by the application to this operation of the organizational principles which had been tested in the "TORCH" operation. There are, therefore, logistical and organizational lessons to be learned from the application of the Army Group system to these two campaigns which merit further study, but it is clear that no fixed functions can be assigned to an Army Group; an Army Group's administrative task is largely dictated by the logistical organization which is to support its operations.

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The most gigantic armada in the world's history was to be assembled in order to launch the invasion of SICILY, which required in all, the movement of some 2,500 ships and landing craft. Counting ships and boats of every type and size in the combined Allied naval forces, the total swelled to more than 3,200, of which 1,700 were assigned to the Western Task Force and the remainder to the Eastern Task Force. About 2,000 craft were to participate in the initial assault.

Although our primary concern was the protection of this vast force from enemy air attack, especially in the SICILIAN NARROWS, we had equally to be on guard against the potential threat of the Italian Navy. Largely inactive in the past, it had incurred heavy losses in its rare and uniformly unsuccessful encounters with the British Navy. We rated the morale of its personnel as low and its tactical ability inferior. But we had to take account of the fact that the main body of the Italian fleet was still in being, that it comprised a formidable force including 6 battleships and 2 8-inch cruisers, and that it must either fight now to defend its own country from invasion or abdicate as a navy. It was strategically well situated to create a real threat, because its main strength was distributed about equally between the bases of TARANTO and SPEZIA within easy reach of SICILY and with complete facility for concentration either side of SICILY through the STRAITS of MESSINA which the Axis controlled.

To counter this threat and to provide the necessary cover of our assaulting forces against surface attack was to be the responsibility of the British Navy, which disposed of a total of 6 battleships comprising the entire 1st Battle Squadron in the MEDITERRANEAN. The 1st Division of the squadron - composed of NELSON, RODNEY and the aircraft carrier INDOMITABLE - was based on MERS EL KEBIR under the direct command of Commander-in-Chief, Mediterranean; WARSPITE and VALIANT and the aircraft carrier FORMIDABLE comprising the 2nd Division were at ALEXANDRIA under Commander-in-Chief, Levant. These two divisions when combined were known as FORCE H which was commanded by Vice Admiral Sir Algernon Willis. KING GEORGE V and HOWE comprising the 3rd Division known as FORCE Z remained in reserve at GIBRALTAR at the disposition of the Commander-in-Chief, Mediterranean. Although the division of the MEDITERRANEAN into two commands, as established on February 20th, was to continue, the British Admiralty had decided that for the duration of the SICILIAN operations Commander-in-Chief, Mediterranean, would be responsible for general naval coordination. Admiral of the Fleet, Sir Andrew Cunningham, therefore, proposed to unite the Levant division with 1st Division to provide the main cover force, and he requested Admiral Sir John Cunningham to sail WARSPITE, VALIANT, and FORMIDABLE screened by 9 destroyers for rendezvous with 1st Division FORCE H at 0630 hours on D-1.

The point chosen for rendezvous was 33°00' N - 18°00' E, far to the Southeast of SICILY, and the area chosen for subsequent concentration lay directly North in the IONIAN SEA, where the combined force could both protect the Eastern flank of the assaults against interference by enemy surface forces and also mask our real intentions from the enemy by appearing to threaten the Western coast of GREECE. For the purpose of this operation, and for the duration of the SICILIAN campaign, the boundaries of Admiral Cunningham's Mediterranean Command were once more expanded at the expense of LEVANT. The Eastern boundary of the MEDITERRANEAN Station, which had been extended on February 20th to include MALTA, was now extended to a line joining the Island of ZANTE on the West coast of GREECE to the EGYPT-CYRENAICA frontier.

Provided no enemy naval threat materialized, the movements of FORCE H on D-1 were to be conducted in such a way as to threaten attack on the West coast of GREECE in the early hours on D-Day, and the force was to maintain its position of cover in the IONIAN SEA through D / 2. It was

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not to be exposed unduly to enemy shore-based aircraft unless in pursuit of the enemy naval forces or unless called upon to bombard the shore of SICILY in support of the army assaults. In the event, the Italian fleet remained passively in its refuge, and FORCE H whose mere presence contained them, maintained a dull and uneventful patrol, disturbed only by serious damage to INDOMITABLE from torpedo attack.

Meantime, HOWE and KING GEORGE V of FORCE Z were to remain in reserve in the Western Mediterranean, available for a number of different contingencies. They could replace casualties in FORCE H if that proved to be necessary, although Admiral Cunningham did not anticipate any such need even if the entire Italian battle fleet became active, because of his calculation that the 4 battleships of FORCE H were more than a match for the 6 Italian capital ships. FORCE Z was to be ready from D-3 to cover the Eastward passage of the assault convoys from the Western Mediterranean, and to operate Southward of SARDINIA to block approaches through the TYRRHENIAN SEA to any elements of Italian surface forces emerging from Western Italian ports. At a date later to be determined, it was to take part in a diversion against Western SICILY, with the object of containing enemy reserves. Subsequently the ships might be used as relief to permit the refuelling of FORCE H.

In addition to the protection afforded by the British battle fleet, each of the two Task Forces had assigned to it a considerable force of cruisers and destroyers both for cover and for close support in the assaults. American naval vessels for the Western Task Force and British FORCE K - 4 cruisers and 6 destroyers - and FORCE Q - 2 cruisers and 2 destroyers - for the Eastern Task Force. A total of 7 British submarines, - SAFARI, SHAKESPEARE, SERAPH, UNRUFFLED, UNSEEN, UNISON, UNRIVALLED - were to act as beacons off the shores of SICILY to guide the task forces to their appointed stations. Commander-in-Chief, Mediterranean was to continue to exercise direct authority over all naval forces until they entered the Task Force Area.

Meantime the movement of all assault convoys until D-1 was designed to conform to the normal routes of through convoys in order to support our cover plan which provided a false D-Day and false destinations for the assault force. The purpose of this plan was to make the enemy believe in a two-pronged threat against the BALKANS and Southern FRANCE, carried out respectively by a mythical British "12th Army" from the MIDDLE EAST and by General Patton's U.S. forces from NORTH AFRICA. An effort had been made to convince the enemy that the assaults were scheduled for the moonless period of the month and that two postponements had already been made - from late May until June and again from late June until late July. By June 21 we hoped to have the enemy convinced that we would assault Western CRETE on July 24, the PELOPONNESUS on July 26, SARDINIA and CORSICA on July 31st, and Southern FRANCE - to synchronize with an attack on Western or Northern FRANCE - on August 4. We provided each of the units of both the Eastern and Western Task Forces with a specific cover destination which would fit the general plan. If our assault convoys from East and West followed the normal convoy routes close to the NORTH AFRICAN coastline prior to the genuine D-Day they would converge in the general area South of MALTA to suggest a threat toward CRETE at the same time that FORCE H maneuvered in the IONIAN SEA to threaten the coast of GREECE. That night they would turn North and approach the shores of SICILY in darkness.

By such a ruse we might hope to retard the reinforcement of SICILY by German troops, reduce the intensity of air and naval attacks on our shipping until D-1, and keep the TARANTO squadron of the Italian Fleet East of the STRAITS of MESSINA. Yet, in view of the vastness of the armada we were planning to assemble, I do not believe that any one of us expected to obtain actual tactical surprise for the assault on SICILY.

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PREPARATIONS

From the beginning the target date of July 10 had assumed that the TUNISIAN campaign would be concluded by about April 30, and we calculated that at the very least it was essential to have a period of six weeks between the conquest of TUNISIA and the mounting of the SICILIAN expedition. When the NORTH AFRICAN campaign ended on May 13, I discovered that the time at our disposal was no more than adequate with no appreciable margin of safety, because TUNISIAN ports were needed to supplement existing facilities for exercise and training of the assault forces, as well as for actual mounting of the expedition, and the expansion of TUNISIAN bomber bases was an essential part of the build-up of the air force for its role in the conquest of SICILY.

Most of the port and training facilities within my immediate area of command as Commander-in-Chief, Allied Force - up to and including TUNISIA - were earmarked for the Western Task Force composed entirely of American units, but the British 51st Division, which had not previously had combined training, was scheduled to undergo such training in the ALGERIAN port of DJIDJELLI, subsequently embarking for the "shore-to-shore" assault at SOUSSE and at SFAX in TUNISIA and the British 78th Division as follow-up was likewise to mount at SOUSSE-SFAX. A combined Training Center was hastily established at DJIDJELLI, where despite interruptions and delays much was accomplished. Necessary landing craft continued to arrive from the UNITED STATES up to within a few weeks of D-Day; trained crews and their craft were diverted on May 30th for participation in the PANTELLERIA operation and were not returned until about four days before training ceased; and one of the two experienced naval officers in the Training Center was also detailed to the PANTELLERIA operation which required his absence during the four weeks when training was at its height. Despite these handicaps three complete naval rehearsals and one combined rehearsal were planned and carried out, before the concentration and mounting of this force in TUNISIA; this was the only combined element of the Eastern Task Force which was able to plan and train with all its units in the same area with full rehearsals by all craft, followed by unhurried and complete briefing by the Force Commander and his staff. Meantime, of the other components of the Eastern Task Force, the Canadian 1st Division was training and mounting in the UNITED KINGDOM; the British 5th and 50th Divisions and 231st Brigade were training and mounting in the MIDDLE EAST, where the shortage of landing craft restricted training to dryshod exercises in the desert and some very incomplete landing rehearsals from June 10th to 17th in the Gulf of AQABA in the Red Sea. The mounting and sailing of the LEVANT section of the Eastern Task Force, comprising 66,000 personnel, 10,000 vehicles, and 60,000 tons of stores in one assault and one follow up convoy, utilized the ports of PORT SAID, ALEXANDRIA, HAIFA, BEIRUT, and BENGHAZI.

U.S. training areas were expanded by the conquest of TUNISIAN ports. Previously, Amphibious Training and Repair bases had been established at PORT LYAUTEY, French MOROCCO, and in ALGERIA at NEMOURS, BENI-SAF, ARZEW, MOSTAGANEM, TENES, and CHERCHELL. PORT LYAUTEY was abandoned when the MEDITERRANEAN facilities had been developed sufficiently to handle additional craft. Shortly after the conclusion of the TUNISIAN campaign the advance party of Commander Landing Craft and Bases, Northwest African Waters, entered TUNISIA and established Advanced Amphibious Training bases at BIZERTE and LA GOULETTE. LST's, LCI(L)'s and LCT(5)'s were used to transfer personnel and material from ALGERIAN bases to the new TUNISIAN bases, and the craft themselves were from this time on based on BIZERTE and LA GOULETTE.

The U.S. 3rd Division, which had been committed too late to participate in the TUNISIAN battle, remained to train and to mount in the new bases. Amphibious training of the 1st Infantry Division and of the 2nd Armored Division was conducted in the ARZEW area. On June 22nd the 45th

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Division arrived at ORAN in combat loaded transports from the UNITED STATES, and by this date all the land forces of the Western Task Force were in their staging areas. Troops of the 45th Division were placed ashore for five days reconditioning training, and all divisions were rehearsed in assault landing. Elements of the 1st and 45th Divisions were moved out to sea by night in loaded transports, accompanied by escorts and gunfire support ships, while the 3rd Infantry Division embarked in the shore-to-shore craft allotted to them to carry out a number of night exercises in the BIZERTE district.

The rehearsals were hurriedly planned because of the shortage of time available and they were at best a "dry run" on a reduced scale. They were not complete, in that only selected units of each Regimental Combat Team were landed on the rehearsal beaches in accordance with the scheme of maneuver planned for the actual assault, and there was therefore no complete unloading of even a limited number of ships and craft. Token rehearsals of this sort invariably stop short of the critical phase of the landing when beaches become heaped with supplies, boats are disabled, and the Army supply system is threatened with breakdown, but even on this limited scale our forces incurred considerable risk from the proximity of enemy aircraft and submarines.

By July 4th these exercises had been completed; all vehicles that had been landed had been sent back to the concentration areas for rewaterproofing and reloading aboard ship; and troops of all divisions had been re-assembled in the staging areas close to the ports for final loading in assault transports and craft. At the same time the 82nd Airborne Division, which had moved from CASABLANCA to its own training area near OUJDA, reached its final staging area near KAIROUAN in TUNISIA. In addition to the average 14 days' maintenance loaded with the assault troops, Eastern Base Section at BIZERTE accumulated 15 days' reserve supplies for 140,000 men, 3 1/2 units of fire, 25% combat vehicles, 10% General Purpose Vehicles, and 10% weapons. Supplies for the 82nd Airborne Division were based at KAIROUAN for movement by air.

Provision for fueling the entire Western Task Force was on a gigantic scale which taxed to the utmost all the facilities within the area of my command. The larger ships of the Force from the time they entered the MEDITERRANEAN required 7 fleet tankers with a total capacity of 75,000 tons of fuel oil, and it was estimated that 212,000 tons of fuel oil and 60,000 tons of diesel oil might be required from D-Day to D + 21, taking account of the small diesel powered ships and all the landing craft which would fuel at BIZERTE and LA GOULETTE. On D-Day shore stocks alone approximated these figures and, in addition, large and small tankers were strategically placed to provide expeditious fueling at ports near the theater of operations, while an additional large reserve was maintained at CASABLANCA.

The air force role during the preparatory period which followed the conquest of TUNISIA was one which combined build-up for the assault with large scale offensive operations designed to facilitate both the build-up and the assault. MALTA, which at the close of November, 1942, was reduced to about one week's petrol supply and could operate not more than about 200 first-line aircraft, rapidly expanded its facilities, until by June, 1943, 600 first-line aircraft were operating from enlarged and newly constructed fields, and during the month prior to the invasion of SICILY MALTA-based Spitfire squadrons and Mosquitos were participating in the ever-increasing offensive against Axis air power in SICILY. On June 11th, primarily as the result of the weight of allied air attack, PANTELLERIA surrendered, and on the following day also LAMPEDUSA. MALTA, GOZO - MALTA's satellite on which an air strip had been constructed - and PANTELLERIA combined could support a total of 670 first-line aircraft. The maintenance plan provided for a high rate of wastage, which never occurred, and as an additional precaution a reserve pool of 50 Spitfires was flown

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into MALTA on D-Day, scarcely a dozen of which were ever called for.

The weight of the attack on PANTELLERIA was expensive in total bomb load - though not in aircraft - at the very time when I was most concerned with the build-up of bombing potential at our TUNISIAN bases to support the invasion of SICILY. For 5255 effective sorties the loss of allied aircraft of NAAF was only 16 damaged and 14 missing, but a total of 6313 tons of explosives had been dropped. On June 18th NAAF reported to my Chief Administrative Officer, General Gale, that after initial difficulties and after meeting unexpected calls for the PANTELLERIA operation, the build-up was proceeding satisfactorily. The margin, however, remained very slight both in bombs and in petrol supply. Fortunately all the convoys were loaded to time and the air forces operating from TUNISIA had just enough bombs and petrol to carry out their daily missions from the time of the surrender of PANTELLERIA until the conquest of SICILY was well under way. That tided us over the critical period.

During the month of Allied air offensives which followed the surrender of PANTELLERIA and preceded the assault on SICILY - June 11th to July 10th, the primary target was the system of airfields in SICILY and SARDINIA, which by the end of June was complete enough to accomodate a total of roughly 600 fighters divided in three nearly equal parts between SARDINIA, Eastern SICILY and Western SICILY. The 19 SICILIAN fields accounted for in the Tactical Appreciation drafted in March had by this time been increased to more than 30 and further expansions were under way; the GERBINI system near CATANIA comprised one major airdrome and 9 satellite landing grounds which were increased to 12 during the week preceding the invasion.

On June 12th Strategic Bombers began an intensive bombardment of the Western fields, both to protect Allied movements in taking over PANTELLERIA and LAMPEDUSA, and to inaugurate the campaign to drive the enemy from his advanced bases in SICILY. CASTELVETRANO, SCIACCA, MILO, and BOCCA di FALCO several miles West of PALERMO, were hit repeatedly in a succession of raids which continued through June 30th and on June 28th the SARDINIAN fields were also heavily attacked. In many cases large numbers of enemy fighters were caught on the ground; BOCCA di FALCO received 220 tons of bombs in one week and largely ceased to operate as a fighter base; both MILO and SCIACCA lost about half their planes as a result of a raid on June 30th, numbers of them undoubtedly dispersed to the Eastern fields which had not yet been attacked. Enemy opposition to the attacks was surprisingly light.

Meantime serial reconnaissance of the Eastern fields revealed that the force of 40 bomber types and 120 fighter types observed on the GERBINI fields on June 26th had been increased by 60 additional fighters by July 1st. During the final week before the invasion these fields received in 35 attacks more than 1320 tons of bombs, with the result that on D-Day the central airdrome and satellites 1, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, and 12 - the last only recently completed - were unserviceable. The Southernmost airdrome at COMISO was likewise rendered unserviceable and other Eastern fields were badly hit, though not bombed into inaction. The total bombardment, in excess of 2,000 tons, broke up the organization of air defense in Eastern SICILY, as earlier raids had virtually broken up organization in the West. The only remaining semi-serviceable fields in the West - MILO, SCIACCA, and BORIZZO - were also heavily bombed in the final week, as well as the SARDINIAN bases.

Strategic's campaign against Axis communications concentrated on the NAPLES area, the SARDINIAN harbors of OLBIA and GOLFO ARANCI, and on the vital communication facilities at MESSINA. During the month preceding the invasion NAPLES itself was heavily bombed four times, with additional raids on neighboring junction points at CANCELLO, BATTIPAGLIA, and SALERNO: OLBIA and GOLFO ARANCI, taken together, four times; MESSINA seven times, including

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three raids on successive nights which blasted the ferry facilities on both sides of the STRAITS of MESSINA.

During the month of Allied air offensive enemy air forces were kept widely dispersed by the wide compass of the bombing; German fighters were virtually defeated and enemy air opposition largely neutralized by losses and by the damage to the SICILIAN airfields; and the enemy's communication facilities for the supply and reinforcement of SICILY had been seriously impaired. During the night of July 9 - 10th there was another large scale bombing of airfields, and of targets in the assault areas, as a prelude to the drawn assaults.

AIRBORNE ASSAULTS

Airborne assaults both preceded and followed the landings, the latter by as much as D + 3, but as a series of highly specialized operations, they logically require preliminary and separate treatment at some length, in violation of strict chronology. For the Allied Nations, it was the first large scale venture in this type of warfare; it was essentially a very difficult operation; and the time for training and organization was very short. The initial airborne assault involved the simultaneous flight of more than 350 aircraft and more than 130 gliders to transport roughly 5,000 men to the dropping zones in SICILY by a water route of about 400 miles.

The original plan which assigned American personnel and equipment of the entire Northwest African Troop Carrier Command to lift British and United States airborne troops successively for separate attacks in the Southeast and the West had been automatically invalidated by the change in the general plan which substituted simultaneous assaults in the Southeastern area of SICILY by both armies. To fit the new general plan, an entire Wing of Troop Carrier Command was assigned to each of the two airborne units, the 51st Wing to the Brigade of the British 1st Airborne Division and the 52nd Wing to the 505th Regimental Combat Team from the U.S. 82nd Airborne Division; and the objectives assigned were no longer the beach defenses envisaged in the Tactical Appreciation, but inland points of strategic importance, to assist the advance of the ground forces.

Between 2210 and 2230 hours on D-1, 137 transport aircraft were to release as many gliders whose British crews were to land in two separate zones in the neighborhood of SYRACUSE, one just South of the City to capture the canal bridge and railway and prevent their destruction by the enemy, the other in the Western suburbs to exploit into the city if possible. The route to be flown from the KAIROUAN area of TUNISIA was plotted via the Southeastern corner of MALTA and CAP PASSERO, the Southeastern tip of SICILY, and up the East coast to the release point 3,000 yards from the shore in the vicinity of SYRACUSE. A little more than an hour later - between 2330 hours on D-1 and 0006 hours on D-Day - 220 C-47's were to drop parachutists of the U.S. 82nd Airborne Division about 4 miles inland and about six miles East of GELA to capture the high ground and road junctions controlling exit from the beaches where the U.S. 1st Division was to land. The route from TUNISIA was necessarily complicated in order to provide sufficient check-points by means of a dog-leg course, East to MALTA, North to the coast of SICILY, West along the coast to a check-point provided by a river mouth and a small lake in the GELA region and thence inland to the dropping zones to be identified from air photographs.

The natural hazards of a major operation involving new and experimental techniques were increased by the conditions prevailing at the time. It had been foreseen that the scant quarter moon, due to set shortly after midnight on D-Day, would scarcely provide ideal visibility to assist the drop and assembly of airborne troops which was scheduled for only shortly before midnight. As indicated in my discussion of STRATEGIC CONSIDERATIONS

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earlier in this report, I had decided on the target date of July 10 as the "favorable period" of the moon, not in any absolute sense, but as the only practical compromise between the irreconcilable demands of the Navy for darkness and of the airborne force for light. Visual aids to navigation were essential under conditions of radio silence imposed by the necessity of securing surprise, and the difficulties of navigation arising from limited visibility were increased by deterioration in the weather. During the late afternoon and early evening a high wind got up, and toward midnight it was blowing 40 miles per hour aloft. The take-off at dusk was well conducted, but planes of both wings missed their first check point at MALTA. The take-off of British and American formations from nearly adjacent fields was simultaneous and some of the latter which lost their way followed British elements to the Eastern coast of SICILY, others going ahead alone. Enemy flak along the shore of SICILY created further navigational difficulties. Finally, preliminary bombing of strong points in the drop zones, intended as an aid to the airborne assault, in some cases obscured check points; a large fire near the lake East of GELA prevented recognition by many planes which finally lost their way at this point.

In the British sector many of the tow pilots, with inadequate allowance for the unforeseen weather conditions, released their gliders too far from the shore, and British Naval vessels of the Eastern Task Force reported the "depressing sight of large numbers of gliders floating in the water" in the area immediately South of CAP MURRO di PORCO at 0500 hours on D-Day. Of 134 gliders which took off from TUNISIA, about 12 landed approximately in the correct dropping zone, 75 somewhere ashore in the Southeastern part of SICILY, and the remainder somewhere at sea. The parachutists of the U.S. 82nd Airborne Division were dispersed from CAP NOTO on the East coast to LICATA, between 50 and 60 miles to the West.

Despite the wide dispersal of their forces, the airborne troops performed prodigies of achievement. In the British sector only 8 officers and 65 men reached their objective South of SYRACUSE at the canal bridge, which they held til 1530 hours on D-Day. At that time the remaining 4 officers and 15 men who had not become casualties were almost surrounded by an enemy force of approximately battalion strength supported by Field Artillery and mortars, but although they were forced to withdraw, the critical situation was relieved by the timely arrival of patrols from the landing forces to drive the enemy back from the bridge which remained intact. The airborne survivors again took over defense of the bridge while the 17th Infantry Brigade of the British 5th Division advanced across it, and the 5th Division subsequently cleared SYRACUSE without difficulty. At the same time elements of one battalion of parachutists who reached the correct dropping zones in the GELA area, although attacked by tanks, accomplished their mission of seizing and holding the high ground to prevent enemy reinforcements from reaching the landing beaches. The operation had a decisive effect on the successful landing and is estimated to have speeded up the inland advance by at least 48 hours.

Meantime the widely scattered airborne elements attacked strong points wherever they found them. In the Southeast glider loads of the British 1st Airlanding Brigade attacked every Italian post they found, contributing greatly to the disorganization of beach defenses and reserves. The 3rd Battalion of the U.S. 505th Parachute Regimental Combat Team seized high ground near VITTORIA, well to the East of GELA, and held it against a Panzer Battalion equipped with Mark VI (Tiger) tanks, until reinforced by the landing forces. The 2nd Battalion of the same regiment dropped near MARINA di RAGUSA in the vicinity of CAP SCARAMIA beyond the Easternmost point of the American landings. It destroyed road blocks and strong points on the highway to RAGUSA itself and captured the town of MARINA di RAGUSA, making contact with the U.S. 45th Division on D / 1, and upon orders of U.S. II Corps, joining the 3rd Battalion of its own regiment West of VITTORIA. The aggressive action of the 505th R.C.T. achieved decisive

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results. Italian prisoners estimated the numbers of American parachutists at between 20,000 and 30,000. In the area of MARINA di RAGUSA, enemy units withdrew about 10 miles, largely due to the presence of parachutists in their rear.

Casualties to personnel had been heavy in the airborne assault, but apart from the loss of gliders, most of the transport aircraft came safely through. Of the 226 C-47's employed by the 82nd Airborne Division only 8 failed to return, while all of the tow aircraft employed by the British 1st Airborne Division returned safely. Later airborne missions were not so fortunate. As the result of an exact and prearranged schedule, it had been possible to notify the vast armada approaching the shore of SICILY that our own aircraft would pass over them during the night, and fortunately the failure of the enemy to observe and to attack the ships proved a further safeguard against the danger of their firing on friendly aircraft. Subsequent airborne lifts had been planned for both areas, but in the nature of the case the prearranged schedule was subject to change in accordance with unpredictable developments once the land battle had begun. A British airborne operation designed to capture a key bridge and high ground commanding the approaches to AUGUSTA from the West on the night of D/D + 1 was cancelled because the disorganization of the defenses and the rapid advance of the British 5th Division made it unnecessary. The 82nd Airborne Division planned to drop the 504th Regimental Combat Team in the GELA area the night of D-Day to join the 505th, but the confused situation existing in that zone during the day led to postponement, and only on the following day was it decided to fly the mission that night, with disastrous results.

*Look for info on
+ ground, in the 2d S.
and not from the
Commander's command, in
detail*

The time was too short to permit sufficient warning to reach all the ships rimming the Southeastern shore of SICILY: the same dog-leg course, sufficiently complicated before, now had the additional disadvantage that it followed the actual battle-front for about 35 miles; and the AA gunners on ship and shore had been conditioned by two days of air attack to shoot at sight. The air transports approached the ships only shortly after an enemy air attack and immediately came under "friendly" fire, with the result that 23 aircraft failed to return and half of those which did return were so badly damaged as to be out of commission. On this occasion, although weather conditions were better than at the time of the original airborne assault, faulty navigation again resulted in a wide dispersal of the parachutists all the way from GELA to the East coast, and their unscheduled arrival at many points led to fatal confusion. Even the 1st Division in whose area they were supposed to drop carried the 504th RCT as an unidentified German Parachute Regiment on its G-2 report. As a result, on an administrative move to our own rear area, it suffered casualties in excess of many units in combat, and its total losses were in excess of any real damage inflicted on the enemy. In all, approximately 5,000 American parachutists were employed in these two operations, and the casualties were as high as 20 to 25%. On D + 4 the bulk of the 504th and 505th RCT's were assembled in a bivouac area near GELA, and the 82nd Airborne Division reinforced by an Infantry RCT and supporting artillery was assigned a zone of action on the extreme left of the American sector and prepared to act as an Infantry Division. Here it performed brilliantly in mopping up Western SICILY by the capture of TRAPANI on July 23rd.

The later British Airborne mission encountered similar difficulties, but accomplished more valuable results than its American counterpart. It was scheduled for the night of D + 3/D + 4, but it had been impossible to determine the exact routing until D + 2, with resultant delay in the notification to all convoys along the route. The force consisted of 105 troop carrier aircraft and 31 tow aircraft for gliders, lifting nearly 2,000 men in all. Of 129 aircraft which took off, 26 returned early because of engine trouble or intense Flak off-shore and over the dropping zone. The Senior Officer of H.M.S. WISHART in escort of a follow-up convoy, which had already begun the turn-around from SYRACUSE somewhat behind schedule, reports that

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from 2130 hours to midnight on D / 3 a "most confusing air defense situation" prevailed because, although warning of the approach of friendly aircraft had been received that afternoon, the Commodore can scarcely have had time to get the message to all his ships before dark. Despite the utmost efforts of the Naval escort to prevent it, merchant ships opened fire at the transports as they flew directly overhead. As in the Western Task Force area, the situation was complicated by the presence of enemy planes. It is an ironic commentary on this confusion that the Greek destroyer KANARIS, which had rescued British and American victims of their own Flak, signalled two messages in rapid succession, the first designed to prevent the convoy from firing on friendly aircraft, the second to complain that she herself was under attack by enemy planes. Eleven aircraft were lost and 40% of the total number put out of commission, primarily as the result of our own AA fire, because the airborne report describes enemy fire as inaccurate and "Allied Naval fire as very accurate and concentrated", adding with what must seem a touch of understatement - "We need their cooperation".

The objective in this operation was the bridge over the SIMETO River, providing the only ready exit from the high ground into the CATANIA plain to the North and the plan was to surprise the defenders before they had the opportunity to blow the bridge and to hold it until the arrival of the landing troops of the British XIII Corps. In this case a much higher proportion of the airborne forces reached the objective, 56 transport aircraft dropping their parachutists on or near the correct dropping zone - though 24 dropped their troops far from the correct zone - and 13 of the tow aircraft releasing their gliders at the proper point for accurate landings, except for one of the latter which crashed. Approximately 200 airborne troops with 5 anti-tank guns got into action against the bridge, and captured it, removing the demolition charges. As in the similar operation in the SYRACUSE area these forces were later forced to retire, but advancing elements of XIII Corps regained the bridge in time to find it still intact.

Both Army Commanders testified to the decisive importance of the missions accomplished by the airborne operations: Commander, U.S. Seventh Army, stating that his successful landings and rapid advance inland could not have been achieved at such light cost and at such great speed without the action of his airborne division; Commander, British Eighth Army, estimating that the airborne assaults on the two bridges - South of SYRACUSE and South of CATANIA - coupled with the widespread confusion created by the vagrant airborne detachments, accelerated his advance by no less than 7 days.

The price paid for these achievements was much too high, partly because of Allied inexperience in mounting a complex and large scale operation of this type, partly because of lack of sufficient time for planning, training and coordination. Needless losses occurred from the AA fire of our own forces, because of inadequate coordination between the services, but equally needless losses occurred as the result of inadequate navigational training of transport aircraft pilots, roughly 60% of whom lost their way and only about 30% of whom reached their correct destination.

It was evident that we still had much to learn about airborne operations and on July 23rd I appointed a board of officers to review the recent operations, in order that the lessons to be learned from our mistakes should be put to good use in planning for subsequent operations of this type.

THE LANDINGS

On June 29th the headquarters of FORCE 141, shortly to emerge from anonymity as 15th Army Group, moved from ALGIERS to LA MARSA in TUNISIA. During the first week in July commanders moved to their war stations.

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Admiral Cunningham was established at MALTA on July 4th and by July 7th General Alexander and I had joined him there to watch the approach and assault phases of the operation. At this stage, when naval factors predominated, my chief concerns were enemy reconnaissance and the weather.

By the morning of D-1 all of us expected to have lost surprise. Although undoubtedly the air force took a fairly heavy toll of enemy reconnaissance aircraft, it is almost incredible that they should not have made determined and sustained efforts to get information about our convoys from at least D-3. During the afternoon of D-1 we watched the fighter control room at MALTA for signs of enemy reconnaissance, but there were almost none. At 1630 hours one German aircraft saw a very small portion of the convoys, and at 1930 hours another German aircraft must have seen all the convoys. Meantime, there were signs that during the day the Germans were expecting an assault on the Western part of the island; reports from all sources indicated that they were marching and counter-marching madly from East to West that day, and continued to do so the day following the assault. There is reason to believe that troops defending the assault beaches got little more than an hour's warning, and though shore searchlight batteries occasionally probed the darkness just before the landings occurred, they apparently found nothing to report. By the time of the assault we were all of us convinced that, contrary to earlier expectations, a large degree of both strategic and tactical surprise had been achieved.

On the other hand, the weather, which had promised fair, turned so threatening the night of D-1 as to give me serious concern for the U.S. Seventh Army landings on beaches which were in general inferior, and which were, moreover, exposed to the strong Northwest wind which blew that night. The effect of the wind on airborne operations has already been described. Between 1630 hours and midnight its strength was about 30 miles an hour and Admiral Hewitt reports that it reached a velocity of more than 35 miles an hour in the Western Task Force area, where the U.S. troops were to land. As it turned out, the weather was just threatening enough to put the Italian coast defenses off guard, without interfering seriously with the landings. But, though the wind steadily abated after midnight, conditions remained very difficult for the assault.

The planning and execution of the approach left nothing to be desired from the standpoint of seamanship and navigation, and proved to be one of the highlights of the operation. LCT convoys made the heaviest weather of it and inevitably a few were delayed as much as two hours by the high sea, but H-Hour had been set for 0245 hours with an allowance of 2 1/2 hours between arrival at release position and H-Hour. In most cases assault waves were not more than a few minutes late, although in the case of the U.S. 45th Division landings at SCOGLITTI, which was most exposed to wind and sea, H-Hour was postponed by a full hour.

Pre-assault and support naval gunfire on beach defenses and prearranged targets was so devastating in its effectiveness as to dispose finally of any doubts that naval guns are suitable for shore bombardment. Modern guns in cruisers and destroyers are of high angle, capable of ranging on reverse slopes and on targets far inland. The fire-power of vessels assigned to gunfire support exceeded that of the Artillery landed in the assaults, and the mobility of the ships permitted a greater concentration of fire than Artillery could achieve in the initial stages of the assaults. The accuracy and effectiveness of the bombardment reduced casualties and damage to landing craft. While the Eastern and Western Naval Task Forces supported the landings, a special force of 2 cruisers and 2 destroyers was detached from FORCE H to carry out operation "ARSENAL", a diversionary bombardment of CATANIA and TAORMINA on the East coast. At CATANIA a "satisfactory oil fire" was started: from TAORMINA came an Italian radio operator's message "There is a war on here".

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The landings in general did not encounter serious opposition. Shore batteries did not put up vigorous resistance; some were not even manned at the time of attack; those which caused trouble were for the most part quickly silenced; there was sporadic rifle and machine gun fire. The British 5th and 50th Divisions encountered some light opposition in the AVOLA Sector just South of CAP MURRO di PORCO, but the 231st Brigade got ashore and inland very quickly on the Eastern shore of the CAP PASSERO peninsula, and the 51st Division had no particular difficulty on the Southern tip of the peninsula. The Canadian 1st Division had a bad beach to negotiate on the Western shore of the peninsula, which was exposed to the full force of the weather, but they too got ashore against indifferent opposition and were able to press quickly inland. One Commando landed farther West and accomplished a perfectly coordinated assault on one of the coastal batteries, only to discover that the guns were dummies.

The U.S. Seventh Army landings were faced everywhere with bad weather conditions, and encountered, on the whole, more serious resistance, although the degree of resistance varied greatly on the different beaches. At SCOGLITTI the landings under cover of supporting fire from destroyers were virtually unopposed, and the establishment of the beachhead was actually achieved in shorter time than had been anticipated. Near GELA the 1st Division encountered heavy initial opposition at some beaches and very little at others. In the LICATA area the 3rd Division met enemy counter-fire on only a few of the beaches. The entire army kept up to schedule and pushed well inland toward its objectives.

Once the beachheads had been established on approximately 100 miles of shore line, combined naval and military forces faced the no less difficult task of establishing supply over the beaches. Weather conditions continued to hamper unloading on the exposed Western flank of the assaults, where every evening a fresh Westerly breeze came up, and the organization and operation of the beaches proved to be one of the greatest difficulties in this operation as it had been in the NORTH AFRICAN landings. The critical condition, as is always likely to be the case, set in from about noon on D-Day to the night of D plus 1, when the supply requirements of the landing forces were particularly pressing; it was also the period of the most determined enemy air attacks. Part of the difficulty arose from the limited time and opportunity for thorough advance training of all the Shore Parties which combined naval and military elements. Although there was less complaint of confusion and congestion from the beaches in the British sector, that was due, at least in part, to the more favorable weather conditions and better beaches. In both British and American sectors it was evident that an inadequate labor force for unloading was the chief bottleneck.

In the face of all the difficulties, the achievement was highly creditable. On D plus 1 Admiral Cunningham made a personal inspection of the difficult conditions in the Western sector, and although he does not ordinarily speak in superlatives, his praise for the way the American Navy got their stuff ashore was unstinted; he had special words of commendation for Admiral Kirk who had the most difficult conditions of all to cope with at SCOGLITTI. All commanders agree that it was the outstanding performance of the amphibious D.U.K.W.'s which, more than any other technical factor, solved the problem of large-scale maintenance over the beaches. Their ability to unload LST's and pass directly over the beaches to the dumps immediately behind speeded up the unloading process and tended to minimize congestion on the beaches themselves, although in some instances they proved so useful that they were diverted too far inland to perform their proper function.

In a little less than two days, from H-Hour on D-Day to 2359 hours on D plus 1, 15th Army Group landed a total of about 80,000 men, 7,000 vehicles, 300 tanks, and 900 guns. The facilities of the beaches were

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augmented almost immediately by the capture of ports: the small port of LICATA was seized and opened to shipping on D-Day; SYRACUSE was entered on the same day by British troops, on the next day by the port party, and on the day following by all the personnel ships of the D plus 3 convoy to discharge their 16,000 troops. On July 13th the troops were discharged in a little less than 4 hours. AUGUSTA was likewise available for unloading on D plus 3.

Casualties and losses of shipping from air attack were surprisingly light because of the high degree of air superiority achieved by our own air force. The Navy had been prepared to accept losses as high as 300 of the 2000 vessels employed in the initial assault. In the British sector there was no attack until 1015 hours on D-Day and during the days immediately following there were intermittent daylight attacks and an increasing number at night, but in all only 3 M.T. ships and one hospital ship, fully illuminated, were sunk. In the American sector, during the first three days of the operation there were 89 plotted raids aimed at the assault areas, of which 26 were intercepted and driven off before reaching their targets. The remaining 63 which penetrated into the attack area, were in most cases engaged by our own fighter cover and on the whole inflicted little serious damage. U.S. losses were 2 destroyers, 2 submarine chasers, and half a dozen landing-craft, with varying degrees of damage to about 20 other ships.

During the entire period of the assault, our airforce maintained constant air cover from MALTA, GOZO, and PANTELLERIA and on D-Day alone roughly 1200 fighter sorties were flown. Heavy bombers continued to attack the few remaining serviceable airdromes; while both heavy and medium bombers ranged widely against Axis communications, transport and troop concentrations. Meantime, the rapid advance of our ground forces gained for our own use advanced bases in SICILY. PACHINO and GELA airdromes were occupied on D-Day, COMISO on the night of D plus 1, and both PONTE OLIVO and BISCARI on the day following. The fields were quickly repaired and on D plus 3 one RAF Wing, the 244th, (less one Squadron) was flown into PACHINO at first light.

On July 12th I boarded the destroyer PETARD at MALTA to survey the situation on the SICILIAN shore. I reached the Westernmost point of the landings at LICATA about dawn, visited Admiral Hewitt aboard MONROVIA, and went ashore for about half an hour. I left the area at 0755, and during the remainder of the morning steamed Eastward about two miles off shore. There was hardly a shell or a bomb to be heard, and the outstanding impression was one of complete serenity. Landing craft were proceeding on their lawful occasions from ship to shore; it looked more like a huge regatta than an operation of war. Convinced that the invasion had been successfully launched, I returned to MALTA, and thence to TUNIS to await General Alexander for a conference on subsequent operations.

The command arrangements had worked well. Admiral Cunningham, General Alexander, and I had all been together at MALTA during the naval phase of the operation, and our contact with Air Marshal Tedder's Air Headquarters at TUNIS, while not perfect, was entirely adequate. Once the U.S. Seventh and British Eighth Armies were well established ashore, the immediate direction of the campaign became the responsibility of 15th Army Group Commander, General Alexander, and of his two army commanders, Generals Patton and Montgomery. From this time I ceased to concern myself directly with the details of the SICILIAN operations, although, of course, its progress was a vital factor in future planning. With respect to this particular function my single concern became one of time, and of providing to Alexander everything he needed to insure speed.

THE CONQUEST OF SICILY

No strategic plan can anticipate every possible contingency which may

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develop once the initial objectives have been secured. When the beach-heads and airfields of the Southeast had been gained, the major objective was MESSINA which was the key to the island, directly on the line of the British Eighth Army's advance up the East coast. During the preliminary phase of the advance, the role of the U.S. Seventh Army on the left was to protect its captured port and airfields, - LICATA, PONTE OLIVO, BISCARI, COMISO - and to guard Eighth Army's left flank from enemy reserves which were likely to be drawn in from Western SICILY. Thus while Eighth Army was advancing due North to capture CATANIA and the GERBINI airfields, Seventh Army was to deepen its bridgehead only to the extent necessary to protect the flank of this advance and to consolidate their own hold on LICATA and the airfields. The map drawn to illustrate my final outline plan marked the approximate limit of the initial operations by a straight line extending from above ACIREALE, just North of CATANIA on the East coast, to PALMA di MONTECHIARO, not far West of LICATA on the South coast. Yet within ten days of the landings, the roles of the two Armies were largely reversed, with the Eighth Army held up by the concentration, during the second week, of German strength in the CATANIA area while Seventh Army struck rapidly Northwest toward PALERMO, largely against Italians, to cut the island in two.

During the first week Seventh Army had been faced by the bulk of the infantry of two German divisions in SICILY - the HERMANN GOERING and the 15th PANZER GRENADIER - and by nearly all the German tanks, totaling some 160. In all, the Germans launched four separate counter-attacks prior to July 16th, of which the first and most critical on July 11th penetrated to within 1000 yards of the 1st Division beachhead at GELA and was stopped only by the devastating combination of rocket guns, anti-tank grenades, tanks, artillery, and naval gunfire, which knocked out between 10 and 16 of the 40 - 50 attacking tanks. The failure of this and subsequent counter-attacks led the German withdrawal, and between July 17th and July 20th the German formations successively disengaged from Seventh Army front, moving Eastwards into positions opposite Eighth Army.

Despite bearing the brunt of German attack during the first week Seventh Army scored impressive advances, especially by the 3rd Division on the left flank, which on July 12th had secured the important road junction at CANICATTI beyond the original "Yellow Line" established by Field Order No. 1. On July 13th a Seventh Army directive expanded its scope of operations by ordering this point to be held, while reconnaissance was pushed still further West to AGRIGENTO.

The day following, General Alexander turned the direction of Seventh Army advance toward the Northwest and enlarged the field of Eighth Army operations correspondingly, to take in the network of road communications LEONFORTE - ENNA in Central SICILY, connecting via the Southern slopes of MT. ETNA with CATANIA on the East Coast, while assigning to Seventh Army the extension of the same road system Westward and South via CALTANISSETTA - CANICATTI. This gave to Eighth Army a second axis of Northward advance, in addition to the main coastal axis aimed at CATANIA and GERBINI. From the junction point of the two armies in the ENNA region the boundary between them was projected due North to the North Coast near SAN STEFANO. The role of the Eighth Army was still conceived to be the primary one of capturing MESSINA, with Seventh Army acting as flank guard against enemy reinforcements coming from the West.

General Alexander's July 16th directive to Seventh Army was still based on the same strategy. It stated that when the initial objective had been achieved, as outlined in the previous directive, Eighth Army's mission was to drive the enemy into the MESSINA peninsula by an advance on three main axes: Northward along the coast from CATANIA; Eastward via LEONFORTE - REGALBUTO - ADRANO; and Northeast via NICOSIA - TROINA - RANDAZZO; the latter two encircling MT. ETNA from the West. To Seventh

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Army was assigned the mission of protecting the rear of Eighth Army as it pivoted Northeast, in two phases, first by establishing a secure base with one division in the area VILLAROSA - ENNA - CALTANISSETA, second by thrusting North to hold road junctions at PETRALIA and South of RESUTTANO.

By the time the directive was issued, Seventh Army advance toward its initial objective had been swifter than anticipated, and on July 17th General Alexander changed the directive by freeing Seventh Army to "drive rapidly to the Northwest and North, capture PALERMO, and split the enemy's forces." On the next day, he dispatched the following message to Seventh Army:

"On capture of PETRALIA you will take advantage of the situation by pushing North a detachment to cut the coast road thereby splitting the island in two. As soon as you are established on the general line CAMPOFELICE-PETRALIA-CATERINA-CALTANISSETA-AGRIGENTO you will advance Westwards to mop up the Western half of SICILY, but this operation must not be started before you are ready to operate from a secure base as given above."

By July 20th Eighth Army progress in the CATANIA plain had been virtually stopped, and from July 21st to August 4th it was at a standstill. Two Regiments of Parachutists of the 1st Fleiger division, which had arrived by air on July 12th and 13th, began to appear as reinforcements on Eighth Army front from July 14th; by July 20th German formations from the HERMANN GOERING and 15th PANZER GRENADIER Divisions which had disengaged from Seventh Army front had moved into positions for the defense of CATANIA. The enemy's defenses were aided by the network of canals, drainage ditches, and rivers which criss-crossed the plain and opposed a formidable barrier to armor; the foothills of ETNA which backed the plain afforded the enemy superior facilities for observation. By July 20th Eighth Army had established a bridgehead over the DITTAINO river into the Catania plain, but for the next two weeks its repeated and persistent attacks were stopped with heavy casualties by continued heavy and stubborn resistance of the German forces along the line of the SIMETO river and the railway to CATENANUOVA.

The concentration of all the German forces in the Northeastern corner of SICILY, with the majority facing the right flank of Eighth Army in the CATANIA region, led to still further modification of previous strategy. It was by now clear that as a result of our operations Italian resistance had weakened considerably, but the Germans were bitterly contesting Allied advance and reinforcing as rapidly as possible. I did not expect prolonged resistance in Western SICILY, but in view of the difficult country of the Northeast, combined with German tenacity and skill, I did not anticipate the fall of MESSINA until Mid-August, a forecast which proved in the event to be substantially accurate.

To bring maximum weight against the German forces, General Alexander on July 20th decided that future operations would be designed to make PALERMO the main axis of supply for Seventh Army and to develop a combined offensive against the Germans by bringing Seventh Army into line with Eighth Army for a break through to MESSINA. Seventh Army was to exploit the demoralization of the Italians by thrusting to PALERMO, but on reaching the North Coast, it was to push strong reconnaissance Eastward toward MESSINA, into what had been previously Eighth Army Sector, along two axes, the coastal road, and the road PETRALIA-NICOSIA-TROINA-CESARO which had formerly been designated as Eighth Army's Northern Axis of advance. Finally, Seventh Army was directed to back up these reconnaissances in strength if the situation permitted.

On July 22nd elements of the U.S. 2nd Armored and 3rd Division met

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at the outskirts of PALERMO. Their plan for a coordinated attack was unnecessary; no resistance materialized, and at 2000 hours PALERMO surrendered. Elements of the 3rd Division had moved with amazing speed, one battalion of the 30th Regiment advancing 54 miles in 36 hours, much of the distance cross-country, and all three battalions of the 7th Regiment after an all night move by motor transport, marching between 32 and 35 miles during the day, with one sharp engagement on the way.

The second phase of Seventh Army mission was thus completed, with only isolated pockets of resistance to be mopped up in the West, and on July 23rd, General Alexander directed that preparation for the final phase be undertaken immediately. Stating that in order to bring about the rapid collapse of the German forces it was imperative that Seventh Army exert strong pressure on their Northern flank and "maintain this pressure constantly", the directive ordered that maximum strength be applied to the Eastward thrust along the two main axes, provided by the coastal road and the road NICOSIA-TROINA-CESARO, leaving minimum forces for mopping up and maintaining order in Western SICILY. Supply bases were to be shifted to PALERMO as rapidly as possible. In order to coordinate the action of Seventh and Eighth Armies, the former was to begin its drive "as early as possible" and in any event by August 1st at the latest. That the enemy expected some such threat was indicated by the arrival of the German 29th Motorized Division in the North coast area.

General Patton immediately moved all non-divisional artillery of the Seventh Army to II Corps, and issued warning orders for the movement of 3rd Division and 9th Division - when it arrived in SICILY - to II Corps Sector. On July 31st, he ordered an attack to be begun the following day, operating in close conjunction with Eighth Army. Air Forces, which had maintained an intensive scale of effort since the landings, were ordered to disrupt enemy rail and road movement in the Northeast corner of SICILY by bombing key points in his communication system on a carefully controlled plan. Naval Task Force 88, consisting of 2 cruisers and from 4 to 6 destroyers was to operate along the North Coast of SICILY to support the advance of Seventh Army along Highway 133 with Naval gunfire on request, and by effecting advance landings of military units when possible. Ships of the Royal Navy were available to Eighth Army for the same purposes on the East coast. WARSPITE had already bombarded CATANIA on the evening of July 17th, the only occasion on which a battleship was so employed.

Eighth Army's supply lines through the ports of AUGUSTA and SYRACUSE were already in good working order, but the task of putting PALERMO in condition to supply Seventh Army was extremely difficult, and there was not much time to spare. The harbor was a shambles from our own bombardments, and at the time of Seventh Army's entry, a total of 44 vessels of all types were sunk in the channels and at the docks, reducing port capacity to about 30%. It required more than a month of work to bring the port to 60% capacity, but on August 1st, 5 personnel ships and 7 cargo ships were able to unload elements of the 9th Division.

With the fall of PALERMO it was possible to organize the flow of supplies from two directions: from the South through GELA, LICATA, PORTO EMPEDOCLE forward to NICOSIA; from the West through PALERMO to CEFALU on the North coast, the terminus of the operating railroad at that time. On August 3rd, a beach was opened near SAN STEFANO, farther forward, and during the following ten days, was used as a discharge point immediately in the rear of the advancing troops. Two Italian schooners were loaded at PALERMO for discharge at the beach, and LSTs from South coast ports rounded the Western tip of SICILY to bring rations, gasoline and ammunition to SAN STEFANO.

As the Army advanced and supply lines became extended, new beaches were opened for the coastal supply movements, which augmented stocks of

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ammunition and rations built up in PALERMO from deep-draught vessels, and materially eased the strain on land transport. Since road and rail transport was persistently hampered by enemy demolitions and mining, the movement of essential supplies by sea direct to the advancing armies materially hastened the end of the campaign.

As the triangle of resistance narrowed, it was possible to coordinate even more closely all three Services, as well as the operations of Seventh and Eighth Armies, for the final rout of Axis forces in SICILY. After the fall of CATANIA and TROINA during the first week of August the previous front of roughly 170 miles shrank to about 45 miles, enabling Seventh and Eighth Armies to operate as a single unit, and permitting the concentration of air attack on an ever narrowing corridor of escape, whose flanks remained open to attack from the sea.

Against CATANIA itself there were a total of 530 bomber sorties up to August 5 and the official report by NAAF remarks that "CATANIA provides a signal example of the process of isolating an important objective by systematic bombing of every line of reinforcement and approach." On August 2nd General Alexander reported that the previous 3 days of air effort against the Germans had been very heavy and that Eighth Army was "well satisfied" with Allied air support. The fall of CATANIA was precipitated by a characteristic application of General Montgomery's strategy of the "Left Hook" by sending British 78th Division to seize CENTURIPPE, the key to the advanced positions in the center of the German line, in order to force a general withdrawal. On August 5th Eighth Army captured CATANIA as a result of this skillfully planned and skillfully executed maneuver, which utilized superior numbers, surprise, and pressure applied suddenly and correctly at the vital point.

The TROINA battle, also one of the bitterest of the campaign, lasted from August 1st to August 6th, during which time Seventh Army sustained 24 counter-attacks. In the same period German positions in TROINA were the target for 265 fighter-bomber sorties and General Patton's Seventh Army Report emphasizes the aid of dive-bombers in the final capture of the town by the 1st Division on August 6th. On the following day Eighth Army patrols were several miles North of CATANIA and MISTERBLANCO and 78th Division captured ADRANO. The advance was slow and difficult in the face of demolitions, booby traps and mines, but there were increasing indications of German exhaustion.

I had already reported to the Combined Chiefs of Staff that the North coast road was almost unbelievably difficult and that small landing operations along that coast offered almost the only means of maintaining the pace of the advance. Almost all the bridges had been blown between PALERMO and MESSINA by the retreating enemy. The Engineers performed prodigies of construction to overcome all obstacles and Seventh Army employed amphibious "end runs" to keep up the relentless pressure which largely frustrated the enemy's delaying tactics and ended by driving him from the island. On August 8th the U.S. 3rd Division in conjunction with Naval Task Force 88 executed the first of three amphibious landings 2 miles East of SAN AGATA to out-flank German positions at SAN FRATELLO which had stopped advance along the coastal road for 4 days. German efforts to reform and reorganize a defense system on the CAP ORLANDO - NASO line were similarly frustrated by a second "end run" at BROLO, 2 miles East of ORLANDO on August 11th.

SAN FRATELLO was the last major resistance on the North coast road and RANDAZZO was the last strong position on the Southern Axis. On August 12th, 78 Division of Eighth Army converged on the position from the South with U.S. 9th Division coming from North and West, after passing through U.S. 1st Division. On the following day 9th Division captured the town. Two further amphibious landings on August 16th, one on

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Seventh and the other on Eighth Army flank, failed to catch up with the speed of the enemy's retreat. Early in the morning on August 17th patrols of the U.S. 3rd Division entered MESSINA, not far ahead of patrols from Eighth Army.

CONCLUSION

Ever since the fall of CATANIA it had been evident that the enemy was preparing a general evacuation of SICILY, and despite the relentless pressure of Allied land, sea, and air forces, he was able to extricate large numbers of German personnel with light equipment, by virtue of what my Intelligence described as "probably the most concentrated A.A. protection yet encountered" to cover the escape corridor to the mainland. Yet total Axis casualties were heavy, 164,000 dead, wounded, and prisoners, of whom 32,100 were German as compared with total Allied casualties of less than 20,000 killed, wounded and missing. Losses of heavy equipment were also large; 78 German tanks and armored cars, 287 German artillery pieces of various types - SP, Field, A.A. A/T, - and 3500 M.T. vehicles. For the axis the loss of SICILY was both a military and political disaster of major proportions.

Seven months earlier the Combined Chiefs of Staff had set modest objectives for the campaign: (a) to make our lines of communication in the MEDITERRANEAN more secure; (b) to divert as much German strength as possible from the Russian front during the critical summer period; (c) to intensify pressure on ITALY. The operation achieved all these, and much more, even though it did not have the desired effect of inducing TURKEY to abandon neutrality and to cast her lot with the Allies.

The shock of the invasion, accompanied by the heavy bombing of key points on the Italian mainland - particularly the bombardment of the marshalling yards in the ROME area on July 19 - exposed the bankruptcy of the Fascist regime, and led directly to its overthrow. At 2300 hours on July 25th, King Victor Emmanuel proclaimed the resignation of Mussolini, and when Marshall Badoglio's government was installed, I correctly interpreted it as ITALY's first step toward abandonment of her German ally and master. An Armistice was signed on September 3rd. It was announced on the evening of September 8th as the prelude to invasion of the Italian mainland which was scheduled for dawn the next day, but practically speaking, ITALY had been out of the war since the invasion of SICILY.

In January 1943 the Combined Chiefs of Staff could have hardly foretold the collapse of ITALY as the immediate result of the SICILIAN operation which they had ordered me to undertake, nor the enlarged strategic gains which that debacle would ensure. The automatic extension of German military commitments in Southern FRANCE, and the BALKANS as well as in ITALY made SARDINIA and CORSICA untenable and opened the mainland of ITALY to invasion. It is impossible to measure how much German air strength and ground forces were withdrawn from RUSSIA, but it is generally admitted to have been sufficient to aid the RUSSIANS considerably. Goebbels, who occasionally speaks some measure of truth, has blamed the treason of her Italian ally for Germany's defeats in RUSSIA.

The loss of an ally, however feeble, was a blow to German prestige which could hardly be disguised from the German people to whom the bonds of the ROME - BERLIN Axis had been trumpeted for years as forged in steel. The German rescue of Mussolini and his reappearance in the fresh but tawdry trappings of a Fascist Republican Leader was a tour de force more worthy of opera bouffe, than of high politics.

Finally, Allied forces of all services and of all arms had demonstrated even more perfect team-work than in the closing stages of the TUNISIAN campaign, achieving complete and major victory in the space of

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38 days. Of the ground forces under my command, the British Eighth Army earned fresh renown, and Seventh Army, which was the first United States Field Army to operate as a unit in this war, distinguished itself by the vigor and brilliance of its fighting and its relentless pursuit action.

Nine months after the initial landings in NORTH AFRICA, the Allied Force had not merely cleared its shore of enemy forces, but had wrested from him the SICILIAN bridge to use as our own in an advance on to the Italian mainland.

NOTE:

The outstanding tactical lesson of the campaign was, for me, at least, the potentialities of airborne operations.

As outlined in this report our technique was not good. Crews of planes were inadequately trained; in our inexperience we did not allow enough time for planning and training, particularly in coordination; our losses were inexcusably high, with blame about equally distributed among the several services, and with a large measure falling upon me because of my failure to make better provision against misunderstandings, particularly in the "follow-up" operations. The only excuse was an intense desire to push ahead - to reinforce quickly - in the hope that the whole defense might collapse within a very few days. But in spite of all this the Airborne troops contributed markedly to success, in both sectors. We must exploit our position of superiority in air power, superiority in air transport, and availability of trained airborne troops to combine these assets with superiority in other fields, notably command of the sea and in armored forces. By so doing we can apply crushing, sudden and devastating blows that will hasten the final downfall of Nazidom.

(signed) DWIGHT D. EISENHOWER

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